

The Story of Punch-kun



It is heartwarming story that has been capturing the hearts of people all over Japan. This is Punch-kun, a baby Japanese macaque—or 'Snow Monkey'—who lives at the Ichikawa City Zoo in Chiba."



Punch was born in July 2025. Because it was his mother's first deliver or due to her weakened condition from the sweltering summer heat, she showed no interest in raising him, so he was raised by human caretakers. Unable to stay close to his mother, he felt very lonely and cried often.



To help him feel safe, the zookeepers gave him a soft, orange stuffed orangutan. Punch-kun immediately fell in love with it. He hugged it tight, slept with it, and even dragged it behind him wherever he went.



But a monkey cannot live with a stuffed animal forever. To live a healthy life, he needed to join the other monkeys. This process is hard because monkeys have a strict social hierarchy. At first, the other monkeys were mean to him, and he would run back to his stuffed toy for comfort.



However, by early 2026, Punch-kun began to 'graduate' from his toy. He started playing with other babies and even hitching rides on the backs of adult monkeys. His story has become a symbol of 'Kizuna'—the bond between the keepers, the community, and the animals.



Punch-kun's journey shows a side of Japanese culture that values empathy and collective support. Next time you visit Japan, you might want to stop by Chiba to see how much he has grown!

